

SPORTSTAR OF THE YEAR (FEMALE)

Smriti Mandhana

Age: 28



Discipline: **Cricket**

Smriti Mandhana, a left-handed opening batter, is a cornerstone of the Indian women's cricket team. Under Smriti's leadership, the Royal Challengers Bengaluru won its maiden Women's Premier

League title earlier this year. She amassed 300 runs in 10 innings, including a crucial 39-ball 31 in the final to help her side post a comfortable win against the Delhi Capitals. In the Women's Asia Cup in July this year, she scored 157 runs across four matches at an average of 57.66 and a strike rate of 137.30, finishing as the third-highest run-scorer of the tournament.

Achievements in the 2024 season:

- ✪ Equalled the record for most ODI hundreds by an Indian during the series vs South Africa-W
- ✪ Broke the record for most runs by an Indian woman in a bilateral ODI series
- ✪ Led RCB to its maiden WPL title
- ✪ Fourth highest run-scorer in WPL 2024



Avani Lekhara

Age: 22



Discipline: **Shooting** **(SH1)***

**The SH1 category is for athletes with movement restrictions in their arms, legs, or lower trunk, or who are without limbs.*

Avani Lekhara created history at the Paris

Paralympics 2024 by successfully defending her women's 10m air rifle shooting standing SH1 title. She became the first Indian woman to win two gold medals in the Games' history. Avani also created a new Paralympic record with a score of 249.7 in the 2024 final and shattered her previous record of 249.6, which she set three years ago on her Games debut at Tokyo 2020, where she also won a bronze in the Women's 50m rifle 3 positions SH1. The 22-year-old has won seven gold medals in National Shooting Championships between 2016-20 and has won multiple medals at World Cups. Lekhara is the recipient of the Major Dhyan Chand Khel Ratna Award — the highest sporting award in India — and was also conferred the Padma Shri in 2022.

Achievements in the 2024 season:

- ✪ Won her second Paralympic Gold by winning the women's 10m air rifle shooting standing SH1 title at Paris 2024
- ✪ Created a new Paralympic record with a score of 249.7 in the 2024 final